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Years of Healthy Life Lost Due to Different Causes of Disability

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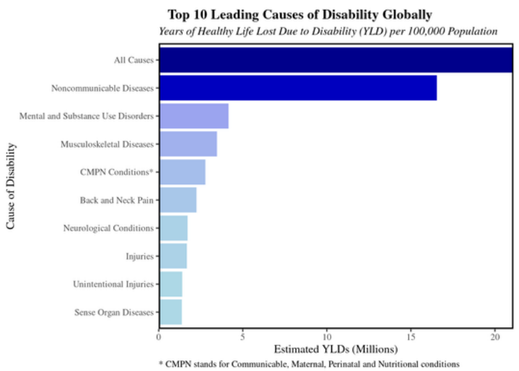
Research Questions

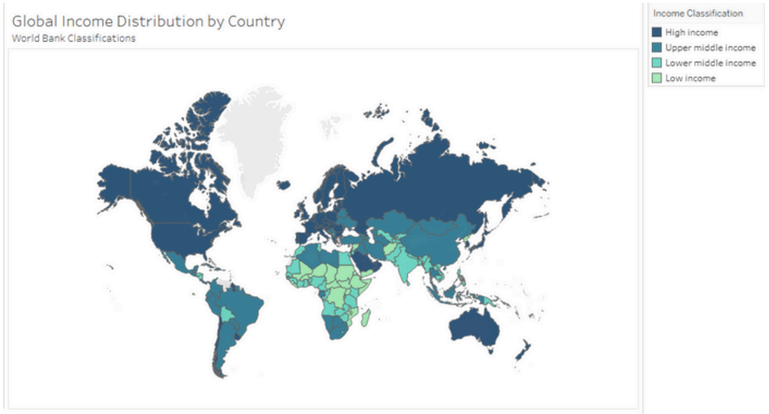
What are the most prevalet causes of disability?
How is wealth distributed geographically, and what is the correlation between this and disability?
How do disability rates differ between male and female populations?

Data

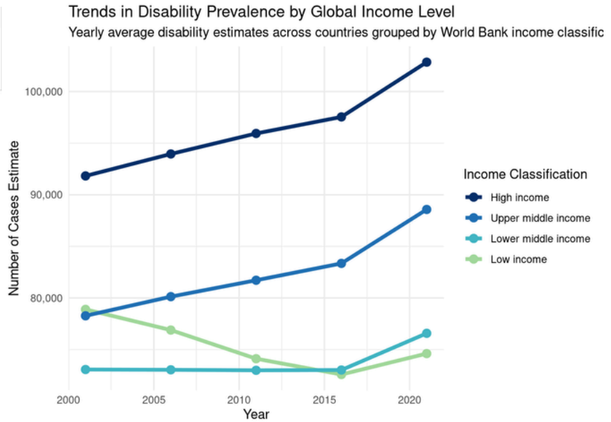
By analyzing the World Health Organization (WHO) Global Health Estimates from 2024, we can identify trends in disease burden and mortality.



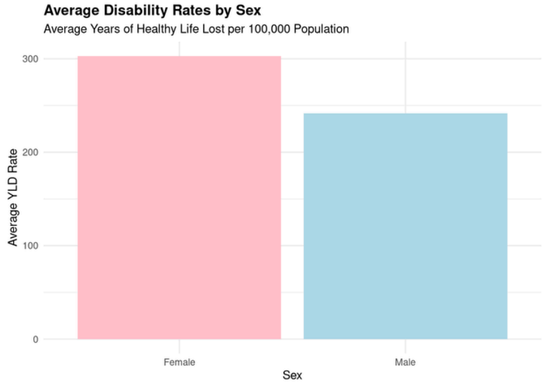
Here we see that noncommunicable diseases are the leading cause of disability globally. These are diseases that cannot be spread from person to person.



This classification reflects economic disparities worldwide and highlights regional trends in income levels, with high-income nations concentrated in the Global North and lower-income nations predominantly in the Global South.



The plots show that higher-income countries report more disability cases on average. However, this likely reflects better access to healthcare and diagnostic services rather than a true difference in prevalence.



We see that females experience, on average, over 50 more years of healthy life lost to disability compared to males. This suggests that females may be more vulnerable to certain types of disabilities, or experience disabilities at higher rates or severities.

Limitations

A significant limitation is the lack of population-adjusted data—without knowing what percentage of each country's population is affected, we can't determine whether disability is genuinely more common in wealthier nations or if these countries are simply diagnosing and reporting cases at higher rates. Future work should focus on incorporating population-level metrics to better assess true prevalence and to account for underreporting in lower-income regions.